



The dough is kneaded until it is elastic and smooth. The dough is gently divided, flattened out, and rolled into its signature sausage shape after resting (and doubling in size). It is then baked until golden brown and dusted with flour. An artisanal baguette stays fresh for up to eight hours.

“The baguette to the French is what the *roti* is to Indians. We eat it every day,” says Montay. However, he adds that Indians are used to softer bread and find the crust of the baguette hard. But that doesn’t stop the baguette from being popular in the country. Complimentary bread baskets at restaurants nearly always have slices of baguettes—to be had with olive oil or as an accompaniment to soup. Baguettes are staples at bakeries across metros such as L’Opera, Theobroma, Suchalis in Delhi; Kitchen Garden by Suzette, Baker’s Dozen, Mag Street Kitchen in Mumbai; and Cafe Noir and Des-

Think of France and you can’t help but think of the crusty baguette—crunchy on the outside, soft on the inside. The French eat nearly 10 billion pieces every year

serted in Bengaluru. They are also available at grocery stores such as Foodhall and Modern Bazaar.

The baguette has inspired everything from art to fashion. In 1997, Fendi launched the Baguette bag named after the way women would carry the French loaf of bread under their arm. The Baguette bag celebrated its 25th anniversary in September during the New York Fashion Week. “It’s not a bag, it’s a baguette!” declared Carrie Bradshaw, Sarah Jessica Parker’s character in the HBO hit show *Sex and the City*, in 2000, cementing the Fendi Baguette as a pop-cultural icon.

A test of a baguette’s quality is said to be the crackling sound made when you break a piece of it. But the truly best way to tell if a baguette is good: just eat it. *Bon appétit.* **BT**

@smitabw